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Housing Benefit

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How to claim

> Housing Benefit is being replaced by Universal Credit. Most people will need to claim Universal Credit instead (/housing-and-universal-credit).

Check if you're eligible for Housing Benefit (/housing-benefit/eligibility) before you apply.

You can either apply:

- through your local council (/apply-housing-benefit-from-council)
- as part of a Pension Credit (/pension-credit) claim, if you're eligible for this

You'll need to provide evidence to support your Housing Benefit claim (/housing-benefit/supporting-your-claim).

If you're applying for Pension Credit

You can apply for Housing Benefit as part of your Pension Credit application.

Apply for Pension Credit online (/pension-credit/how-to-claim) or contact the Pension Service to claim.

The Pension Service will send details of your claim for Housing Benefit to your council.

> Pension Service
> Telephone: 0800 99 1234
> Relay UK (https://www.relayuk.bt.com) (if you cannot hear or speak on the phone): 18001 then 0800 99 1234
> Monday to Friday, 8am to 6pm
> Find out about call charges (/call-charges)

Claiming in advance and backdating

You can claim in advance by up to 13 weeks (or 17 weeks if you're aged 60 or over), for example if you're moving. You will not usually get any money before you move.

You might also be able to get your claim backdated - ask your council (/apply-housing-benefit-from-council).

Appeal a decision

If you're unhappy with a housing benefit decision, you can challenge the decision (/appeal-housing-benefit-decision) by:

- asking the council to review their decision
- appealing against it at a tribunal

Get help and advice when appealing a decision

You can get free help and advice from:

- Citizens Advice (https://www.citizensadvice.org.uk/benefits/help-if-on-a-low-income/housing-benefit/problems-with-housing-benefit/challenging-a-housing-benefit-decision/)

- Shelter (https://england.shelter.org.uk/housing_advice/benefits/housing_benefit_revisions_and_appeals)

You can also seek advice from a legal adviser or solicitor (/find-legal-advice/find-legal-adviser).

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View a printable version of the whole guide (/housing-benefit/print)

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